

Session 11: Dreamers in Pharaoh's Prison

Key Takeaways

- The theme of dreams and visions in Genesis is foundational to later apocalyptic literature and emphasizes the important role of dreams in the world of the biblical authors.
- A three-day period often indicates that the theme of testing appears nearby in the narrative.
- The Yoseph story contains many instances of paired or parallel events or repetitions. These doublings often point to a single reality, and they invite readers to consider why this narrative is focused specifically on two brothers, Yoseph and Yehudah.

Yoseph Interprets Dreams in Prison

¹ And it came about after these things,
that they sinned, **the cup-bearer of the king of Egypt and the baker** ,
against their master, against the king of Egypt,
² and Phar'oh was angry with his two officials,
against **the captain of the cup-bearers** ,
and against **the captain of the bakers** ,
³ and he gave them into the prison,
the house of **the captain of the butchers** ,
into **the round-house** ,
the place where Yoseph was imprisoned.

⁴ And **the captain of the butchers** appointed Yoseph with them,
and he served them,
and they were there for days in the prison.

⁵ And **the two of them** **dreamed a dream** ,
each **his dream** in one night,
each according to the **interpretation** of his dream,
the cup-bearer and the baker of the king of Egypt ,
who were imprisoned there in the round-house.

⁶ And Yoseph went to them in the morning,
and he saw them, and look, they were distraught,

⁷ and he asked the officials of Phar'oh,
who were with him in the prison of the house of his master, saying,
"Why are your faces bad today?"

⁸ And they said to him,
"We **dreamed a dream**,
and there is no one to **interpret** it."
And Yoseph said to them,
"Don't **interpretations** belong to Elohim?
Please, recount it for me."

Genesis 40:1-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

⁹ And **the captain of the cup-bearers** recounted his dream to Yoseph,
and he said to him,
"In my dream, look:
a vine was before me,
¹⁰ and on the vine were **three tendrils**,
and as it was blooming its blossom rose up,
its clusters ripened with grapes.
¹¹ And the **cup of Phar'oh** was in my hand,
and I took the grapes,
and I crushed them into the **cup of Phar'oh**,
and I gave the **cup** into the hand **of Phar'oh**."

¹² And Yoseph said to him,
" **This is its interpretation** :
The **three tendrils are three days** .
¹³ Within **three days** **Phar'oh will lift up your head** ,
and he will return you to your post,
and you will give the **cup of Phar'oh** into his hand,
according to the custom of the beginning, when you were his cup-bearer.

¹⁴ However, if you can **remember me** with you,
when the good thing happens for you,
and please act with loyal-love towards me,
and **make remembrance of me** to Phar'oh,
and bring me out from **this house**,
¹⁵ because I was stolen from the land of the Hebrews,
and even here I have done nothing,
that they should have put me in **this pit**."

16 And **the captain of the bakers** saw that the interpretation was good, and he said to Yoseph,
“So then, as for me, in my dream, look:
Three baskets of white-bread were upon my head,
17 and on the most-high basket were some from all of the food of Phar’oh,
the work of a baker,
and the birds ate them from the basket upon my head.”

18 And Yoseph answered and said,
“ **This is its interpretation** :
The **three baskets are three days** .
19 Within **three days** **Phar’oh will lift up your head** from upon you,
and he will hang you upon a tree,
and the birds will eat your flesh from upon you.”

Genesis 40:9-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

20 And it came about on the third day,
it was the birthday of Phar’oh,
and he made a feast for all **his servants** ,

and he lifted up the head of **the captain of the cup-bearers**
and the head up off **the captain of the bakers**
in the midst of **his servants** .

21 And he returned **the captain of the cup-bearers** over his cup-work,
and he gave the cup into the palm of Phar’oh
22 and **the captain of the bakers** he hanged,
just as **Yoseph** had interpreted for them.

23 But **the captain of the cup-bearers** **did not remember** **Yoseph** ,
and he forgot him.

Genesis 40:20-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Two Dreams of “Exaltation”

As Yoseph sits in the lowest of low places (in a dungeon in Egypt), he hears the two dreams of other exalted figures who have also been brought down low into the prison-pit. The similarity between Yoseph and these two fellow prisoners invites the reader to compare the importance of these dreams. If these officials have two dreams that result in a restoration of some kind, we begin to hope that Yoseph’s two dreams of exaltation might also come true.

Dreams of Bread and Wine

Notice how the two dreams of the officials are about coordinated images of provision and sustenance (bread and wine). The coming famine will bring a scarcity of just these things, so this story points forward as well as backward.

Reflection Question

What role do dreams play in Genesis and beyond in biblical literature?